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(AI-Generated Session Notes)

From Pilot to Production: 3 Companies Share the Reality of AI Rollout

Date & time: Oct. 15, 11:40 AM-12:25 PM
Track: AI Transformation / Strategic AI



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SVP Strategic Operations, Veroot

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Amanda Yoho

Chief Executive Officer, Proformex

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David Peace

CEO, Innovatus Imaging

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Chief Content Officer, SmarterX & Marketing AI Institute

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Session Description

Inside most companies, putting AI into production takes more than a green light. There's legal to clear, IT to align, teams to bring along, and a business to keep running while you do it.

In this session, SmarterX's Mike Kaput hosts a candid discussion with three business leaders doing the real work of AI adoption inside established organizations across healthcare, logistics, and financial services.

During it, you'll learn:

- **The actual projects:** What each company has put into production and the result
- **Internal buy-in:** How they got leadership, legal, and IT on board and where the resistance came from
- **Change management:** What rolling AI out across teams really looks like and what makes adoption stick
- **What didn't work:** Where things went sideways and how each leader course corrected
- **Operational lessons:** What they would do differently, what surprised them, and what leaders should know before scaling AI internally

If you're responsible for turning AI from experimentation into operational value, this session will give you a clearer picture of what it actually takes.

Key Quote

> *"AI is a toddler, very smart, not often right."* **- Kris Beck**
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> *"It's not human in the loop; it's AI in the loop."* **- Amanda Yoho**
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> *"My experience is the people that are most at risk is senior management."* **- David Peace**

Session Summary

Moderated by Mike Kaput, Chief Content Officer at SmarterX and Marketing AI Institute, this panel brought together three leaders of established, growing businesses outside the tech world to share what AI adoption really looks like: David Peace, CEO of Innovatus Imaging, which repairs ultrasound probes and MRI coils in a highly regulated, FDA-audited space; Kris Beck, SVP of Strategic Operations at Veroot, a trade compliance software company serving the logistics industry; and Amanda Yoho, CEO of Proformex, a SaaS platform for life insurance and annuity portfolio management.

The panelists opened with where AI is delivering. Beck said Veroot's engineering team is shipping three to five times more features, while a small marketing team uses AI to iterate on its ICP and messaging every month. Yoho described engineers using tools like Claude Code and Cursor moving upstream into product design and problem-solving. Peace's biggest surprise was less technical: AI helped him write sharper job specs that led to two successful executive searches.

Much of the conversation centered on guardrails and people. Peace encourages experimentation on company-sponsored platforms but keeps existing stage gates for anything that reaches the product or the market. Beck described an apprenticeship model, with leadership learning advanced skills first and then training managers and individual contributors, plus a multi-agent QA pipeline built after MCP-fed dashboard data started drifting. Yoho emphasized documenting processes and success criteria so AI tools have real business context to work from.

The panel also tackled the messier side of AI-generated work. Yoho now responds to low-quality AI output with an immediate conversation rather than a red pen, and noted AI-written redlines

slowing down deals. Peace and Yoho both warned that AI-made content increasingly looks and sounds the same, with Yoho recalling nine of ten startup pitch decks that looked identical. On the future of human contribution, Beck stressed that a human must always be accountable and raised concerns about how entry-level employees will build the judgment to verify AI, while Yoho reframed "human in the loop" as "AI in the loop."

In closing advice, Yoho urged leaders to lead by example and invest in documentation, Beck recommended picking a project, pushing past your comfort level, and focusing on how fast AI can do something right, and Peace argued that the people most at risk from AI are managers who block experimentation or fail to guide it.

Key Takeaways

- **Keep the stage gates:** Encourage experimentation, but require anything going into the product or out to the market to pass through existing approval processes.
- **Document everything:** Written processes, success criteria, and stakeholders give AI tools the context they need and make internal AI initiatives more likely to succeed.
- **Apprenticeship beats training alone:** Having leaders learn advanced skills first and then work alongside managers and teams on real projects builds confidence that training sessions alone don't.
- **Keep a human accountable:** Someone must own the accuracy of AI output, supported by checks such as agent-based QA steps that validate data before it reaches dashboards.
- **Protect what makes you distinct:** AI-generated content increasingly looks the same, so have a human finish and sign off on external messaging.
- **Leadership is the real risk:** Managers who can't understand, support, or set guardrails for AI experimentation become the bottleneck to adoption.